

**Exploring the Identity Formation, Socialization and Political Engagement of  
Second-Generation Immigrants**

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## **Abstract**

This thesis seeks to add to existing literature concerning the identity formation and socialization of the children of immigrants born in the United States of America, otherwise known as second-generation immigrants. This second-generation navigates the culture of both their respective heritage and the mainstream American culture. In combination with this distinctive experience, socializing agents such as social networks, schools, and organizations shape how individuals formulate their identities. In turn, these identities align with certain political preferences, behaviors, and attitudes, which may influence the degree to which these individuals are politically and civically engaged. Examining this experience included exploring the evolution of how the American government defines what it means to be American and how the American public defines American identity and perceives immigration. It also involved investigating the variations among first- and second-generation immigrants in general, as well as within immigrant groups. Furthermore, it engages with understanding the influences of certain variables on the socialization processes of individuals. This thesis concludes with a case study: the experiences of the Cuban American community. Second-generation immigrants undergo a unique socialization process which may result in significant differences between them and their immigrant parents. However, their political preferences and identification, and thereby the extent to which they may differ from their parents', depend on the degree of influence that each socializing agent has. Methodologically, this work draws from various fields – sociology, political science, psychology – to provide more insight into the experiences of second-generation immigrants in American society.

## **Introduction**

Throughout history, America and its egalitarian ideals have functioned as an alluring and hopeful factor for those immigrating to its shores. The American Dream promises a society based on freedom, democracy and equality. That determination and merit will decide the verdict of one's success. While this inclusive and optimistic idea of America is a pioneering achievement, it is vastly more of a dream than a reality. It does provide hope, but it often does not fulfill the promise. People who immigrate to America arrive to a country with contradictions. It claims liberty for all; however, wave after wave of immigrants have continuously been Othered and seen as outsiders — that is until they have assimilated to fit the status quo. This process can alter a person and their family, their culture, identity, perspective, language, etc.

The question of how the identities of immigrants and the succeeding generations are shaped by their connections to the process and experiences of immigration is the main focus of this thesis. I plan to focus on second-generation immigrants, the children of those who immigrated. To do so, I will also examine some of the variables that impact the experience of immigration, such as language, relationships with family, friends, peers, education, gender, ethnicity, and race. In addition to examining theories surrounding the aforementioned lines of inquiry, I believe it is important to probe what it means to be an American and how the various answers to that question may influence the identity formation of an immigrant and their experiences.

## **Methodology**

To properly understand and examine the experiences and political engagement of second-generation immigrants, I reviewed both quantitative and qualitative data. I believe that the combined analysis of existing surveys and academic literature produces a well-rounded synthesis.

As this thesis seeks to better understand the experiences of second-generation immigrants, an inspection of the demographic provides important insight. This shall be done through the analysis of a variety of surveys. Observing the countries of origin of the American immigrant population over the course of around 60 years provides context in regards to explaining the evolution of immigration to America. To emphasize the importance of the growing diversity, I shall highlight how first- and second-generation immigrants comprise a sizable proportion of the American population. Moreover, I shall utilize studies which have observed where second-generation immigrants reside in America. In combination, these surveys showcase the significant role that the immigrant population plays in American society.

Taking into account the history and legality of the immigration process, specifically in regards to citizenship, provides important contextual information to the investigation of the experiences of second-generation immigrants. Observing the evolution of the jurisprudence of birthright citizenship produces an understanding of the relationship between the law and how it functions in society in relation to its purpose. Analysis through historical jurisprudence offers an opportunity to understand how the American government employs its immigration law and to examine the degree to which the government's beliefs, objectives and interests align with that of the general American society.

In order to conduct this comparison mentioned above I shall additionally examine a variety of polls and surveys, which focus on how second-generation immigrants identify themselves within the United States of America, which itself is a country whose identity is often evolving. Through the utilization of surveys that ask sample populations of first, second, and third-generation immigrants about their language proficiency and self-identification, I am able to compare the responses and decipher some of the trends and patterns embedded in the process of

immigrating and integrating into American society. Furthermore, I also look at surveys in which the respondents share how they define America and what it means to be American. I propose that this combination of surveys will provide a nuanced understanding that encapsulates the experiences of immigrants, especially second-generation immigrants.

With polls and surveys providing quantitative data, academic literature offers qualitative work that conceptualizes and theorizes the processes surrounding immigration, such as socialization and integration, which involves taking note of the influences of language, familial dynamics, and other socializing agents. There is variation among the sources that I have accumulated. I have obtained research analyzing the unique experiences of second-generation immigrants against studies concerning the intersectionality of race, gender, and class and the connection of this relationship with the institution of immigration. The authors of these works critique other approaches and conclusions, and they develop alternative frameworks that provide a better understanding of the experiences of immigrant families.

Furthermore, I employed an analysis of the Cuban American community as a case study, which embodied the data provided in the polls and surveys, and exemplified the theories discussed in existing literature on the topic. I believe that adopting a sociological and political perspective allowed for a well-rounded examination of what it means to be a second-generation immigrant in American society. There is a growing amount of academic literature that seeks to explain the experiences of being a second-generation immigrant. It is a topic that is influenced by gender, class, ethnicity, and race, which in turn impacts educational and occupational possibilities, resulting in varied experiences for immigrants and their families.

Through the process of writing a thesis, I was made aware of its limitations, which are centered on the fact that I was unable to assemble my own data and research. This means that I

am relying on the existing polls, data, and surveys of other projects. I do believe that recounting the experiences of second-generation immigrants would elevate this thesis, as it would provide direct and personal anecdotes. However, the logistics of conducting original research on this topic are not easily undertaken therefore I employ existing surveys and case studies.

Additionally, while the topic of immigration is expansive and is composed of many differing experiences with the American immigration system, this thesis focuses on the experiences of second-generation immigrants in comparison to that of their parents, who are first-generation immigrants.

### **Research Questions**

How does people's environment affect their identity and, subsequently, their involvement in society and politics? This is a question central to the thesis, and one I will be better able to unravel with the additional aid of literature that is focused on better understanding the variables that are involved in a person's engagement with political affairs. This is the area of primary interest for me, as I seek to synthesize the experiences and identity formation of second-generation immigrants within the process in which political engagement is developed, to better understand this nuanced connection.

There are many variables which are influential in the shaping of second-generation immigrants' identities, therefore it is critical to understand how these factors impact the ways in which one operates socially and thereby politically. For instance, the relationship between first-generation immigrant parents and their second-generation immigrant children has the capacity to shape the identities of second-generation immigrants. Another example is the evolution, over the course of generations, of the role which culture and language play in a country of origin. Examining how the perceived ideas of America and what it means or takes to

be an American may impact the construction of a second-generation immigrants' identity and connection to their heritage will highlight the external pressures which are involved in the socialization process. This may reveal which influences and variables make people politically engaged.

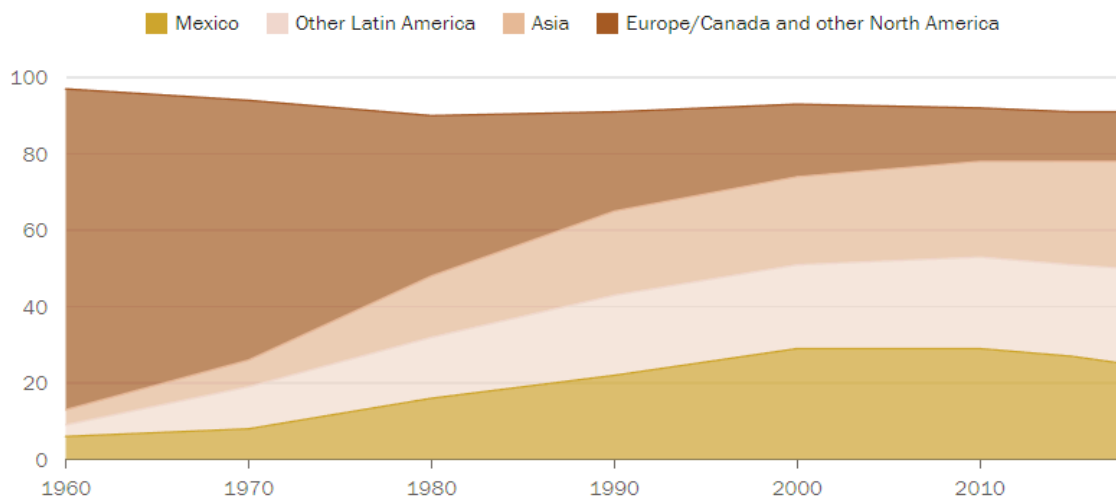
To summarize the aforementioned inquiries, what factors lead to a politically active immigrant community or individual? What are the existing accepted and credible theories about second-generation immigrants and their political activity? What does the existing data regarding second-generation immigrant voter turnout reveal about their political activity and preferences?

### Immigration in Numbers

**Figure 1**

#### ***Origins of the U.S. Immigrant Population, 1960 and 2018***

*% of foreign-born population residing in the U.S. who were born in ...*



*Note.* From the *Facts on U.S. immigrants, 2018*, by Pew Research Center, published August 20, 2020

<https://www.pewresearch.org/race-and-ethnicity/2020/08/20/facts-on-u-s-immigrants/>

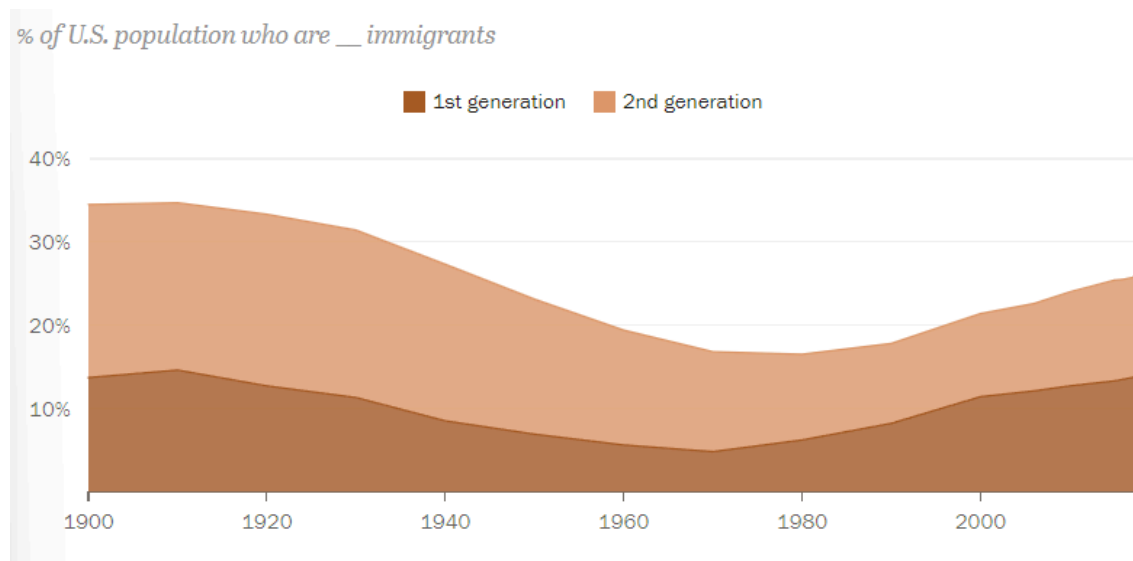
Immigration has steadily increased over the past almost 60 years, which highlights the impact of the Immigration and Nationality Act of 1965, which ended the National Origins Formula, and established the seven-category preference system. This resulted in the prioritization of skilled workers, refugees, and the families of US children and Green Card holders, and implementing a limit on immigration from Latin America. In 1960 there were 9.7 million immigrants residing in the United States, compared to the 44.8 million immigrants living in the United States in 2018 (Pew Research Center, 2020)

This difference of approximately 35.1 million immigrants shows how the demographics of the American population have changed, therefore requiring further investigation of the effects of these changes. Furthermore, it should be noted that the demographics within the immigrant population have also changed over time. In 1960, for example, the majority of immigrants were between the ages of 50 and 79, while in 2018 the majority of those who were foreign-born were between the ages of 30 and 50. Additionally, there has been an increase in variance in terms of where immigrants are originating from, which showcases the effects of the passage of the Immigration and Nationality Act of 1965. In 1960, 84% of immigrants had emigrated from Europe, Canada, and other parts of North America, 4% from Asia, 3% from other Latin American countries, and 6% from Mexico. These numbers are in contrast to the demographics of the immigrant population in 2018 when only 13% of immigrants came from Europe, Canada, or other parts of North America. However, 28% of immigrants came from Asia, 25% from other parts of Latin America, and 25% from Mexico. These changes to the immigrant population highlight how the American population has become increasingly diverse with people of different backgrounds. Specifically, second-generation immigrants constitute a significant portion of the overall population in America. Moreover, a 2020 Pew Research Center study found that in 2018,

12.3% of the U.S. population are second-generation immigrants. This can be observed in Figure 2 (Pew Research Center, 2020). This highlights not only how diverse the immigrant population has become, but also the sizable portion of the population who are second-generation immigrants.

**Figure 2**

***First- and Second-Generation Share of the population, 1900-2018***



*Note.* From the *Facts on U.S. immigrants, 2018*, by Pew Research Center, published August 20, 2020

<https://www.pewresearch.org/race-and-ethnicity/2020/08/20/facts-on-u-s-immigrants/>

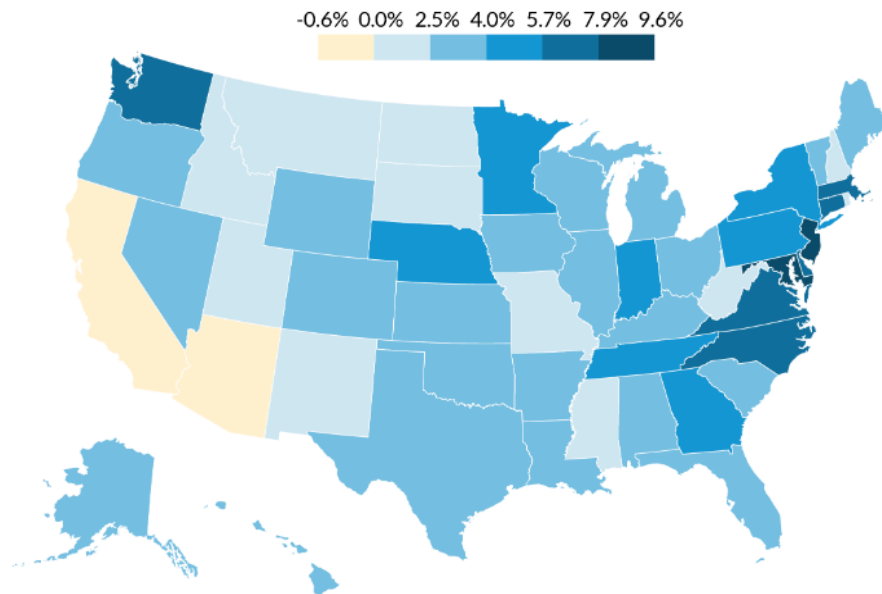
Figure 3 below shows how there has been an overall increase in the distribution of second-generation immigrants – the children of immigrants – across America. The only states to experience a decrease in children whose parents are immigrants were California and Arizona, supporting this trend. Around half (47%) of second-generation immigrants live in major cities, with “New York; Los Angeles; Chicago; Houston; Miami; Dallas; Washington DC; San Francisco; Riverside, CA; and Atlanta” being cited (Woods & Hanson, 2016, 3). However, a 2016

study showed that since 2006 there has been a 56% growth in other cities. These cities include “Seattle, Philadelphia, Austin, .... Charlotte, NC; Minneapolis; Baltimore, Las Vegas, Nashville and Portland, OR” (Woods & Hanson, 2016, 3). A 2019 study by the Urban Institute revealed that around 18.5 million, or 25%, of American children, are the children of immigrants (Urban Institute, 2019). With around a quarter of children in America having at least one foreign-born parent and 23% of all American children being US citizens with at least one foreign parent, a large portion of society has a direct relationship with the institution of immigration (Woods & Hanson, 2016).

**Figure 3**

***The Share of Children Who Are Children of Immigrants Increased Substantially in Some Nontraditional Immigrant Destination States from 2006 to 2017***

Percentage-point change in the share of children who are children of immigrants



*Note.* From *Part of Us: A Data-Driven Look at Children of Immigrants*, by Urban Institute, published March 14, 2019, <https://www.urban.org/features/part-us-data-driven-look-children-immigrants>

Figure 3 also revealed that immigrants have begun to reside in locations that have previously not been primary, long-established destinations for immigrants. The study specifically mentions North Carolina and Nebraska as examples of states that have experienced high percentage-point changes regarding the number of second-generation immigrants in each state. Between the years of 2006 and 2017, North Carolina and Nebraska experienced an increase of 7 and 5 percentage-point changes, respectively (Urban Institute, 2019). This suggests that there is a trend in which the demographics of the populations of individual states continue to change, which may alter the social and political landscape of those states.

### **What Does It Mean to Be “American”?**

#### **What the Government Thinks**

By granting citizenship on the basis of fulfilling certain criteria, a government is outlining who qualifies as an American citizen. However, over the course of its history, the American government, with social movements being the driving force, has changed the requirements an individual has to fulfill in order to be considered an American citizen, thereby highlighting that American citizenship is a political tool, rather than simply just a label.

To hold citizenship in the United States of America, one must either be born in America, have at least one American parent, or become naturalized, with the first two being grounds for obtaining American citizenship at birth. The legal terms for these principles are *jus soli* – being born in America – and *jus sanguinis* – having an American parent (Blakemore, 2018). This concept and codification of birthright citizenship has developed alongside the civil rights movement, as the definition of birthright citizenship has expanded throughout American history.

Birthright citizenship is the principle on which second-generation immigrants – the children of immigrants – are granted citizenship and the rights and freedoms associated with being an American citizen. Therefore, examining the history of the legality of birthright citizenship is critical to understanding how second-generation immigrants' abilities to engage politically have developed over the past almost 250 years.

America officially became a sovereign nation in 1783 by signing the Treaty of Paris, thereby ending the American Revolution. During the early years of American history, laws and institutions were being developed. In the process of establishing the aspects mentioned above, the idea of the American identity was being simultaneously written. This nexus of policy and identity occurred with the passage of the Naturalization Act of 1790 which stated:

Be it enacted by the Senate and House of Representatives of the United States of America, in Congress assembled, That any Alien being a free white person, who shall have resided within the limits and under the jurisdiction of the United States for the term of two years, may be admitted to become a citizen thereof on application to any common law Court of record in any one of the States wherein he shall have resided for the term of one year at least, and making proof to the satisfaction of such Court that he is a person of good character, and taking the oath or affirmation prescribed by law to support the Constitution of the United States, which Oath or Affirmation such Court shall administer, and the Clerk of such Court shall record such Application, and the proceedings thereon; and thereupon such person shall be considered as a Citizen of the United States. And the children of such a naturalized, dwelling within the United States, being under the age of twenty one years at the time of such naturalization, shall also be considered as citizens of the United States. And the children of citizens of the United States that may be born beyond Sea, or out of the limits of the United States, shall be considered as natural born Citizens: Provided, that the right of

citizenship shall not descend to persons whose fathers have never been resident in the United States: Provided also, that no person heretofore proscribed by any States, shall be admitted a citizen as aforesaid, except by an Act of the Legislature of the State in which such person was proscribed. (U.S. Congress, 1789)

Furthermore, it mentions that the children of immigrants under the age of 21 would, through their parents, gain citizenship. This section mentions who is able to be considered for American citizenship. However, by omission, it is understood that those who are indentured, enslaved, and people of color, are prohibited from being able to apply for citizenship. Additionally, women could themselves not apply. As written in the Act above, only free white men could obtain citizenship. The American colonies adopted English common law and norms, an example of which is coverture, a law that remained in place until the 1880s, which states that women did not have legal rights but were seen as the possession of their fathers and then husbands (Women & the American Story, n.d.) (The Editors of the Encyclopaedia Britannica, 2007).

The next major alteration to naturalization law occurred as a result of the Dred Scott v. Sandford case, which made it to the Supreme Court. Dred Scott was a Black enslaved man, who was suing the courts for his freedom. Although Scott lost the case, with Chief Justice Roger B. Taney arguing in the majority opinion that any “person of African descent [could not] be considered a citizen, even if they were born in the U.S.”, this decision prompted abolitionists to continue to seek rights for those enslaved, such as expanding citizenship (Blakemore, 2018). A year before the official end of the Civil War, Attorney General Edward Bates stated that free men born in America were American. Four years later the Fourteenth Amendment was implemented, making it a constitutional right that “all persons born or naturalized in the United States and

subject to the jurisdiction thereof” be considered American; however, Native Americans remained excluded (Blakemore, 2018).

The ruling of another case, *U.S. v. Wong Kim Ark*, in 1898 strengthened the principle of the Fourteenth Amendment as it established a precedent. Wong was born in America to Chinese immigrants, but when Wong attempted to return to America after a visit to China, he was denied reentry, due to the codification of the discriminatory Chinese Exclusion Act, which perpetuated an environment conducive to discriminatory and xenophobic behaviors. The Department of Justice then attempted to use Wong’s situation and case to prohibit specifically those of Chinese descent from American citizenship. However, the Supreme Court ruled in favor of Wong, with Associate Justice Horace Gray writing in the majority opinion:

The Fourteenth Amendment, in clear words and in manifest intent, includes the children born, within the territory of the United States, of all other persons, of whatever race or color, domiciled within the United States. To hold that the Fourteenth Amendment of the Constitution excludes from citizenship the children, born in the United States, of citizens or subjects of other countries would be to deny citizenship to thousands of persons of English, Scotch, Irish, German, or other European parentage who have always been considered and treated as citizens of the United States. (Blakemore, 2018)

The ruling by the Supreme Court cemented that anyone born in the United States would be granted American citizenship, regardless of their racial or ethnic background and family history. This protected the concept of birthright citizenship, which provides immigrants’ children who are born in the United States with the rights associated with American citizenship, such as voting and other privileges. Despite this constitutional precedence regarding birthright citizenship, in an interview with AXIOS during his presidency, former President Donald Trump announced that he

would plan on repealing birthright citizenship through an executive order (Swan & Kight, 2018). A 2015 Pew Research Center study found that 53% of Republicans and 23% of Democrats support this challenge against birthright citizenship. Because of these statistics, it is important to examine the intersection between birthright citizenship, identity, socialization, immigrants and their families, specifically their children born in the United States (Blakemore, 2018).

### **What the Public Thinks**

Various metaphors have been developed to describe the concepts associated with the institution and process of immigration, such as the “melting pot” and the “salad bowl.” These figures of speech are an attempt to translate complex theories and concepts into digestible imagery. While both metaphors illustrate the process of Americanization, the nuances of the concepts they represent highlight the differing beliefs and approaches regarding immigration in America. The metaphor of America as a “melting pot” describes the idea in which innumerable cultures, peoples, countries, and ethnicities come together, eventually assimilating into one homogenized America. Diverging from this perspective is the metaphor of the “salad bowl,” more formally known as acculturation. In this analogy, the various ingredients of a salad represent the accumulation of distinct ethnicities and cultures, emphasizing the heterogeneity of American culture. These different perspectives regarding the dynamic between immigration and American culture provide insight into the subjectivity of what it means to be an American. By comparing studies conducted in recent years, the influences that shape our perceptions of the American identity can be better understood.

A 2017 Pew Research Center gauged American attitudes towards how the idea of the American identity is articulated, ranging from birthright citizenship to the role of language, adopting national customs and traditions, and faith. These preconceived notions have a partisan,

educational, and generational divide. The majority of Republicans taking part in the study find being able to speak English (83%) and sharing American culture and traditions (60%) to be very important for being considered truly American. 61% of Democrats agree that being able to speak English is very important, with only 38% believing that sharing American customs and traditions is very important for being truly American. While a majority (70%) believe that speaking English is an essential component of being American, 81% of those 50 years and older agree with that statement compared to 58% of those between the ages of 18 and 34. This link between age and agreement with statements suggests that generations have a different perception of the role of language in regards to national identity. With younger generations agreeing less with the idea that being able to speak American is a required aspect of American identity, other languages are able to be spoken, thereby challenging the idea held by primarily older generations that speaking English is mandatory to be considered American. Moreover, there is a negative correlation between the education level of the respondents and the degree to which they find being able to speak English to be very important for being truly American, with 79% of those who obtain their high school diploma agreeing with that statement, compared to the 59% of those with a college degree or higher. This same pattern can be noted in the 45% of those who find that sharing American customs and traditions is very important in being considered truly American. When comparing those over 50 to those between the ages of 18 and 34, those over 50 are almost twice as likely to agree with the previous statement. The presence of a negative correlation between educational attainment and concurrence with the importance of assimilating into American customs and traditions is prevalent again, with 54% of those with a high school diploma or less and 33% of those with at least a college degree viewing the adoption of American customs and traditions as very important to being American. While only a minority

(32%) of respondents believe that being born in America is very important to being truly American, upon inspection of the educational attainment of these respondents, there is a link between lower educational attainment and concurrence with this idea. Almost half of those who have obtained their high school diploma or less (47%) concur, which is much more than the 14% of the respondents who have at least a college degree that also agrees. Despite 32% of respondents finding being Christian very important to be considered American, only 31% believe religion to not be important at all. Among those who find Christianity to be a cornerstone of American culture, those over 50 (44%) or with a high school diploma or less (44%) are more likely than those between the ages of 18 and 34 (18%) or with at least a college degree (19%) to find it a critical component (Stokes, 2017).

A nationwide poll, conducted by The Associated Press-NORC Center for Public Affairs Research, aimed to understand the degree to which the American public values certain preconceived notions of American culture and identity, which are influenced by people's pride. The majority of respondents felt extremely proud of its military, history, and achievements in science, technology, arts, and sports, compared to smaller levels of pride felt towards economic achievements, the functionality of democracy, American influence in the world, Social Security, and the treatment of groups in society. The poll revealed that a large majority (71%) believe that the United States is in the process of losing its national identity; however, there are variations in the values that respondents believe to be the most essential components of the American identity. While almost all of the respondents viewed the rule of law (88%), individual freedoms and rights (84%), and the American Dream (79%) as extremely important to the American identity, over half of the respondents also cited the shared use of the English language (73%), the institutions (71%), the idea of America being a place for those seeking protection from persecution (65%), a

shared American culture (65%), the economic opportunities that America provides (55%), and the acculturation of cultures in America (50%). However, 33% of respondents maintain that a culture established by the country's early European immigrants is extremely important to the American national identity. And 40% of respondents also believe that a culture grounded in Christian religious beliefs is important to the American national identity. The intersection of immigration and identity reveals the correlation between the perception of immigrants and the state of America's identity. Around 49% of those who perceive that most immigrants have assimilated into American culture also believe that America's identity is secure. However, those who feel that immigrants have retained their own culture are more likely to say that America is losing its identity. Furthermore, while there is a minority of respondents who regard legal immigration as a major risk, the largest percentage considered legal immigration to be a minor risk to the nation's identity (Connelly et al., 2017).

In 2019, the Associated Press-NORC Center for Public Affairs coordinated another nationwide poll to expand on existing studies and focus primarily on the attitudes of Americans towards immigration, diversity, and their perception of the state of American culture. America is renowned for the egalitarian ideal of the American Dream, as can be seen by the diverse nature of the American population. Overall, the majority of Americans believe that America is strengthened by diversity, with 56% of white respondents, 63% of black respondents and 71% of Hispanic respondents agreeing with the statement, highlighting a slight variation between racial groups. A minority of respondents either felt neutral towards diversity's impact on America's stability or felt that it makes the country weaker. 54% of all respondents aligned themselves with the statement that recent immigrants have mostly retained their own cultures, compared to the 43% who concur with the assertion that immigrants have mostly adopted essential American

culture. Among the latter group are 40% of white respondents, 55% of black respondents, and 49% of Hispanic respondents, in contrast to the 58% of white respondents, 42% of black respondents, and 48% of Hispanic respondents who believe that recent immigrants have retained their respective cultures. A majority (51%) agree that America should be a country with an essential American culture, with most white respondents concurring. However, the majority of black and Hispanic respondents agreed that America should be made up of many different cultures and values (The Associated Press-NORC Center for Public Affairs Research, 2021).

### **American Identity and Attitudes: Trends and Patterns**

The nuances of the American identity can be examined by taking into account the similarities and differences between the previously discussed studies. For example, the significance of the shared use of the English language should be noted, as most Americans across party lines find it an essential part of the American identity. While there is a consensus among Republicans and Democrats regarding the importance of the use of the English language, there is a partisan divide regarding the importance of the adoption of American customs and traditions, with Republicans believing it to be a core component of the American identity. Furthermore, the majority maintains that America should be a country with an essential culture. The culmination of these attitudes reveals the dominating ideal of the American identity; speak English and adopt American culture, with Americans being most proud of their military, history, and accomplishments in the fields of STEM, arts, and sports. These identified hallmarks of American culture can be noticed in the rule of law, the concept of the American Dream, and the granting of individual freedoms and rights, which are the most popular characteristics of American national identity. With this in mind, it should be observed that most of those claiming that America is losing its identity also believe that recent immigrants have retained their respective cultures

rather than adopting an essential American culture. This reveals a sense of worry about the potential effects of immigration on American culture.

### **To Assimilate or to Acculturate**

Immigrants with their customs, values, and traditions are faced with American culture upon their arrival in the United States. This interaction may result in either cultural assimilation or acculturation, depending on various factors. One of these is the pressure of wanting to feel welcomed in a new society. People have a natural tendency to seek approval and acceptance, therefore a possible outcome could be the cultural assimilation of immigrants into American culture. The process of assimilation occurs when individuals from a minority cultural group assume the behaviors and values of the majority group, with their original culture becoming less noticeable. Nevertheless, as immigrant communities have developed, so has acculturation. Cultural acculturation describes when cultures can contribute to each other, thereby constructing a dynamic coexistence of multiple cultures. This heterogeneity establishes a multicultural society. However, as previously stated, there is a large portion of American society that believes that immigrants are not adopting American culture but rather retaining their respective cultures and that America should be characterized by a homogenous culture. This attitude manifests itself in various forms, all resulting in pressure to assimilate into the American melting pot.

This process of either assimilation into or acculturation with American culture transcends first-generation immigrants. The choices made by first-generation immigrants have the capacity to influence the individuals around them and generations to follow, especially their children. It is important to understand how the experiences of first-generation immigrants may in turn shape and influence the experiences of second-generation immigrants especially in regards to the construction of their dual identity. Second-generation immigrants navigate between their heritage

and the American culture, creating a unique mindset. This journey can involve adapting to American norms and practices as a means to socially integrate and make social connections with the community and friends while balancing and maintaining the languages and cultures of one's family. These experiences all have the potential to subsequently influence socioeconomic status and language proficiency which in turn may impact educational and professional attainment.

### **First versus Second Generation**

Differences among parents and their children are a common phenomenon; however, the variation in experiences and language proficiency between first and second generations stands out. Surveys conducted by the Pew Research Center in 2013 highlight these differences in educational attainment, various socioeconomic statuses, self-identification, and language proficiency in both English and their ancestral language (Pew Research Center, 2013).

Around 60% of both second-generation Hispanic and Asian American immigrants think of themselves as typical Americans, compared to 30% of Hispanic and Asian first-generation immigrants. Interestingly, the connection to their heritage decreases over the course of generations, as the majority of first-generation immigrants describe themselves in regards to their country of origin while second-generation immigrants increasingly describe themselves as American. Compared to first-generation immigrants, second-generation Asian and Hispanic immigrants were more likely to be proficient in the English language. This could be attributed to a variety of factors, such as increased exposure to the language and pressures to assimilate. While the overwhelming majority of both groups are fluent in English, it should be noted that Asian first-generation immigrants are almost twice as likely to be conversant in English than Hispanic first-generation immigrants. However, in regards to being able to understand and speak the languages of their families' countries, 50% of Hispanic second-generation immigrants can do

so very well, compared to just 18% of Asian second-generation immigrants. This ability to converse in one's ancestral languages relies on the importance placed on maintaining it. Close to all Hispanic first-generation immigrants believe it is very important for future generations to be able to speak Spanish, with 68% of the second generation concurring. In contrast, fewer than half of Asian first-generation immigrants feel it is very important for future generations to speak their ancestral languages. In the succeeding generation of both groups, the importance of being able to communicate in their ancestral languages decreases. While the value of maintaining one's ancestral languages remains, the combination of these trends highlights the tendency to adopt the English language at the expense of retaining the ability to speak the language of their heritage (Pew Research Center, 2013).

The distinction between first-generation and second-generation immigrants also exists concerning numerous socioeconomic statuses. This can be noted in the various degrees of educational attainment. Overall, more second-generation immigrants are educated at a collegiate level than the general American population and first-generation immigrants, and are more likely to have obtained a high school diploma. Higher educational achievements can influence income, along with other variables. A 2013 Pew Research Center standardized study revealed that across all age groups, second-generation immigrants have a higher rate of income than first-generation immigrants. Furthermore, 11% of the second generation are considered to be in poverty which is less than the 13% of the general American population, in contrast to the 18% of first-generation immigrants who are in poverty. Second-generation immigrants have a higher rate of homeownership than first-generation immigrants, as the second-generation has a homeownership rate of 64%, just a percentage point shy of that of the general American population. The similarities between second-generation immigrants and the general American population should

be observed as they showcase the degree to which the former group has been successful in establishing themselves in their respective communities (Pew Research Center, 2013).

First- and second-generation immigrants share a similar sense of political preferences and party identification. Political behaviors are partially shaped by first-hand experiences and our social network, thereby explaining the degree of consensus among immigrants and the children of immigrants. A study organized by the Pew Research Center in 2013, which focused on the Asian and Hispanic communities, showcases the variance in how first- and second-generation immigrants identify themselves politically. Both communities are predominantly Democratic and experience an increase in political identification among the second generation, as the percentage difference between first- and second-generation immigrants is 8% for Asians and 11% for Hispanics. However, it should be noted that more (71%) Hispanic second-generation immigrants identify themselves as Democratic than Republican (19%). In contrast, 52% of Asian second-generation immigrants identify as Democratic compared to the 32% who identify as Republican. More Hispanic second-generation immigrants describe their political ideology as liberal than those of their first-generation counterparts. In a similar behavior as with party identification, there is not a significant difference between first- and second-generation Asian immigrants. However, there is a clear preference among both Asian and Hispanic first-generation immigrants for a bigger government that offers more services, with almost all Hispanic first-generation immigrants and over half of Asian first-generation immigrants preferring this. The liberal nature of second-generation immigrants can be noted as the overwhelming majority of this demographic supports the LGBTQ+ community and legalizing abortions, which is distinct from the views of the first-generation groups. First-generation Asian immigrants are nearly split in half on their views towards legalizing abortion and accepting or discouraging homosexuality,

while their Hispanic counterparts are far more accepting of homosexuality than legalizing abortions. This stark difference between these first-generations highlights the influence of Hispanic and Asian cultural norms, experiences, and values on the construction of social views (Pew Research Center, 2013).

As previously mentioned, the influence of social connections and general interactions has the capacity to shape attitudes, thereby influencing behaviors. Examples include personal growth, community building, cultural transmission, and social influence. Through these forces, people have the potential to be exposed to various perspectives and experiences. There may be opportunities for mutual support and the establishment of a coalition and shared identity forged through shared or similar experiences. Social groups also have the ability to provide a source of guidance and validation through practiced norms. A 2013 Pew Research Center study provided insight into intergroup relations between first- and second-generation Asian and Hispanic immigrants between each other and other racial and ethnic groups. By taking a closer look at the variation between first- and second-generation Asian and Hispanic immigrants regarding relations to other groups, the nuances and patterns of these relations can be better understood. Concerning relations with each other, and the black and white communities, second-generation Asian and Hispanic immigrants are more likely to get along pretty or very well with the aforementioned groups. This highlights how second-generation immigrants are socially integrated, which means increased interactions allow for the chance of mutual understanding and support between groups that previously may not have been able to connect at that level. However, the difference in how first- and second-generation Hispanic immigrants interact with other groups should be noted. There is a notable disparity, with a 27% difference in their perceptions of getting along pretty well or very well with the black community, a 26% difference

in regards to the Asian community, and a 15% difference in regards to the white community. Data reveals that both groups have the highest level of positive interactions with the white community, then with each other, and then to a lesser degree with the black community. This study revealed that overall, first- and second-generation Asian immigrants experience positive relations with other racial and ethnic groups when compared to first- and second-generation Hispanic immigrants (Pew Research Center, 2013). This claim is further supported by the fact that second-generation immigrants are more likely to have friends who are not from the same country of origin, as well as being more comfortable with the idea of marriage between people of different ethnic or racial backgrounds, with 73% of Asian and 71% of Hispanic second-generation immigrants expressing comfort with inter-racial and -ethnic marriages. Fewer than half of Asian and Hispanic first-generation immigrants, 41% and 49% respectively, feel very comfortable if their child were to marry someone outside their own racial or ethnic community. Only 15% of second-generation immigrants in general are married to someone of a different ethnic or racial background. While there is slight variation among different demographics, there is a pattern of second-generation immigrants of Hispanic (26%), Asian (23%), and black (27%) heritage being more likely to be in an inter-racial or -ethnic marriage than first-generation immigrants, contrasting with the generational consistency of the white community (6%) to marry within that group (Pew Research Center, 2013).

### **Navigating This Experience**

While these aforementioned statistics and data provide insight into the construction and influences of American identity, as well as the nuances of second-generation immigrants, it is important to acknowledge complexities such as variations generated by historical context and geographical location. However, this data serves to provide a foundation to better understand the

various tendencies, experiences, and behaviors of second-generation immigrants, as well as the pressures to balance their ancestral heritage with American identity. Oftentimes, the experience of second-generation immigrants is described as navigating between two worlds. This “balancing act” involves engaging with the expectations of immigrant parents that are simultaneously being challenged by the influences of assimilation, resulting in the process of negotiating and forming a unique identity. This synthesis of cultural influences manifests itself in the ability to maneuver between dual identities through their multilingualism. However, embodying two identities simultaneously may present a challenge in forming one’s selfhood, due to the influences and subsequent pressures of balancing societal and familial expectations and traditions.

As can be observed in the data above, there are various ways in which people constitute what it means to be considered an American. However, there is a consensus that the shared use of the English language and engagement with the status quo of American culture and traditions are extremely important elements of the American identity. Research shows that “patriotism and nationalistic American identity combined are related to less tolerance to cultural diversity, negative attitudes toward minority groups, and restricted criteria for identification as a ‘true’ American” (Li & Brewer, 2004, 736). This indirectly fosters an environment conducive to creating a sense of pressure to assimilate into what is considered mainstream. It is universally known that people tend to desire a sense of belonging. This can be noted in the tendency to want to “acquire an American identity [to become] indistinguishable from their American peers”, however immigrant children and children of immigrants “may [still be] perceived as “unassimilated even when they try hard to abandon their own ethnic identities” (Zhou, 1997, 90).

Frequently, among those with dual identities, efforts to adhere to the norms of one identity come at the expense of the other. To better understand this compromise, it is important to

understand the sources of the norms. Second-generation immigrants have two sets: “one from their heritage culture, which is learned most from the family, and the other from the mainstream culture, which is typically acquired through peers, school, and the broader social context” (Giguère et al., 2010, 15). To gain a deeper understanding of the levels of influence, examining the complexities of these two sets of norms is vital.

These respective sets of norms impact second-generation immigrants as they play a major role in developing one’s identity. Part of identity formation involves discerning what it means to be caught in the dichotomy of cultural identity. As can be observed in the data presented in the preceding sections, there are significant differences between first and second generations in terms of proficiency in the English language and their heritage, identifying as American, relations with different ethnic or racial groups, and views toward social values. By contrasting these variations, the influences of different cultures and experiences can be noticed. In general, the identities of first-generation immigrants are shaped primarily by their respective cultures, while the development of second-generation immigrants’ identities is influenced by American culture and their ancestral culture as “having group memberships in both the heritage culture and mainstream culture is a central aspect of how they define themselves” (Giguère et al., 2010, 15). It should be noted that children who immigrate to the United States at a very young age, to the point where the majority of their life is spent in America, may experience a similar situation and conflict as second-generation immigrants. I shall discuss the need to reexamine the experiences of young first-generation immigrants in greater detail later on.

Another important aspect to be aware of regarding the experiences of second-generation immigrants is the compatibility between one’s heritage and the American culture. Depending on their relationship with preserving their respective cultures, parents may expect their children,

who themselves are experiencing pressures to fit in with the mainstream American culture, to aid in continuing traditional cultural values and norms. In addition to the widely recognized generational differences between parents and their children, there are differing levels of acculturation which may manifest as “culturally-based internal conflict” because culture can “exacerbate intergenerational conflicts for bicultural individuals” (Giguère et al., 2010, 16-18). This conflict is maintained through the worry of rejection by both parties – the culture of one’s heritage and mainstream American culture – as adhering to the traditions and norms of one and not the other, or vice versa, may result in such. Frequently, a common reaction to this aforementioned experience is to actively adapt depending on the given circumstances, for example “when individuals alternate between different cultural interpretive frames as a function of the cues in their environment” (Giguère et al., 2010, 16). This describes the feeling of navigating the expectations and norms of two cultures that second-generation immigrants often encounter. This unique experience plays an interesting role in the development of one’s perspective and psyche, which in turn contributes significantly to how one engages within their community and in politics.

### **Political Socialization and Participation**

Socialization is a process through which “an individual learns to adjust to a group and behave in a manner approved by the group” (The Editors of Encyclopaedia Britannica, 2024). It is an agreed observation that humans are social beings, meaning that there are natural tendencies that primarily contribute to the need to belong. This can be noted in the desire to establish in-groups, thereby creating out-groups as well. While the categorization of people through the use of identities and labeling may supply oneself with a sense of community and identity, it also provides explanations and structure to our society (Mason, 2018).

Identities and communities are intrinsically connected to politics through the dynamic of social networks and civic engagement. It can be noted that the relationship between social psychology and political participation has been documented in research which explains that the causation of political participation is due to “our sense of feeling attached to others... with whom we simply feel socially connected” (Mason, 2018, 104). This perspective reflects the Columbia school model, which represents the sociological take on the matter of socialization, as it focuses on the social influences on a person. In contrast, the Michigan school model, a framework based in the field of psychology, centers its argument on the power of the individual and their choice. While the Michigan school model is known for its focus on the individual, it also engages with sociological analysis like that employed by the Columbia school model (Campbell, 2013). This commonality of sociological analysis of these two models emphasizes the significance of social interactions and networking among individuals, as both highlight the influence of social engagement on political participation.

Existing literature has cited social networks and agents as sources of political mobilization, which it has been suggested, imparts skills required for optimal civic engagement. These include friends, families and institutions such as schools, churches, clubs and organizations. These socializing agents have the capacity to influence the degree to which one is politically engaged. Furthermore, it is through these social structures that concepts, such as norms and convictions, have the potential to be reinforced. This is especially the case as the pressures of group norms are heightened when an individual is surrounded by those similar to them. However, it should be acknowledged that one’s social network serving as a source of political knowledge depends on whether or not said social network is “populated with people

who have greater political expertise” as it makes people “more likely to participate in politics” (Campbell, 2013, 40).

### **Political Socialization within Immigrant Families**

Familial dynamics and structures vary, and thereby how family members socialize and engage with each other does as well. In regards to political socialization, the general literature on the topic suggests that people are familiarized with politics “through the unidirectional intergenerational transmission of political attitudes and orientations, from parent to child” (Wong & Tseng, 2008, 151). In contrast, research specifically focused on immigrant families has hypothesized that “political socialization may be bi-directional,” with both parents and children transmitting information between one another for different reasons and interests (Wong & Tseng, 2008, 151). Furthermore, there are many variables which may influence the political socialization of immigrant families. One of them is the degree to which one is able to express ethnic and cultural pride, which depends on one’s community (Wong & Tseng, 2008). Additionally, a family’s social position, which may be due to education level and length of residency in America, may result in a greater understanding of American politics, requiring less assistance from their American-born children. The significance of this economic capital has been a topic of debate, with proponents of its importance arguing that since it leads to “better educational and economic prospects” those with affluence are more able to exercise their political rights and participate. However, there is evidence to the contrary as “Asian Americans and Latinos generally differ significantly in socioeconomic status attainment, yet they exhibit similar levels of political participation” (Terriquez & Lin, 2020, 749). Additionally, race and experiences with racism may serve as a stimulant to be engaged and involved in initiatives that confront systemic racist institutions and practices (Wong & Tseng, 2008).

Looking into the parent to child transmission process within immigrant families, where the parents are first-generation and the children are second-generation immigrants, the way in which parents socialize with their children is “based on their experiences in the country of origin and in the host society” (Wong & Tseng, 2008, 155). This explains the variation in political knowledge and engagement among various immigrant families, with a parent’s connection and relationship with their country of origin influencing the scope of the political knowledge of their children. For example, when a parent is more engaged with the politics of their home country, they may view American policy in regards to its implications with their home country. This perspective also exposes their children to the events, issues and politics of their parents’ country of origin. In addition to the influences of their country of origin, the socialization processes of parents may also be impacted by their experiences with media and work. These interactions provide an opportunity for exposure to certain issues, candidates, and political activities. However, in immigrant families, parents are “often less familiar with politics in the United States than are their children,” due to their children being more likely to be “quickly become proficient in English and... exposed to US culture through schooling” (Wong & Tseng, 2008, 152).

Conversely, the child to parent transmission process is characterized by the children’s increased exposure to the English language, American culture, and their personal experiences with political institutions and processes, thereby instilling an expansive knowledge of civics and politics. Similar to their parents, the interactions experienced in their daily lives, such as in school or in other social settings, have an influence on their engagement and knowledge of politics. This personal interest in politics may, in itself, lead to children asking their parents about their heritage, resulting in an opportunity for an expansion of political awareness and engagement. The symbiotic nature of this transmission process should be noted, as the children

are oftentimes involved in the parents' encounters with the political procedures. Due to their proficiency in English and tendency to be more familiar with American politics, "youth perform 'brokering activities'" on behalf of their parents, which includes "language translation and explaining government documents, aspects of the US political system, and particular political issues" (Wong & Tseng, 2008, 155). However, it should also be acknowledged that the extent of the children's political knowledge, beliefs and actions depends on the degree to which children are involved in said brokering activities. Moreover, over the course of their upbringing, youth develop habits, skills, attitudes and values from the aforementioned social networks and agents which evolve into long-term political interests and commitments (Wong & Tseng, 2008).

An interesting behavior between members of immigrant families is the cyclical nature of obtaining more political knowledge. As mentioned above, due to the fact that children of immigrant parents are more likely to encounter political institutions personally, thereby expanding their political knowledge, they may be more likely to "further explain political issues to their immigrant parents" (Wong & Tseng, 2008, 155). This suggests that they may be more likely to also seek out more information and educate themselves further. In turn, parents "respond by trying to increase their own knowledge of politics in order to maintain interaction" (Wong & Tseng, 2008, 152).

While the focus on the political socialization within immigrant families has been limited, the findings of studies which concentrate on this specific familial structure provide important insight into the socialization process of immigrant families compared to those other families. For example, the influences of the parents' relationship to their country of origin and its politics on the political behaviors and attitudes of their children (Wong & Tseng, 2008). It should be acknowledged that there exists a demographic divergence, as "those of Latin American origin are

more likely than those of African, European, and other origins to explain or translate political materials to their parents” (Wong & Tseng, 2008, 164). Children with immigrant parents are more likely to “explain political concepts to their parents... than those with one or both US parents,” especially in regards to being “more likely to explain elections, political parties, freedom of speech and democracy” (Wong & Tseng, 2008, 160). Compared to their counterparts who do not have immigrant parents, children from immigrant families are less likely to be politically active; however this is due to the extent to which socializing agents, like schools, parents, civic organizations, provide access and engagement which stimulate political participation.

It is also important to highlight the role which education plays in the socialization process of children, in this case children of immigrants, but also the quality of the education which students receive, as curricula which critically examine American history and politics impart civic competency and awareness. Similar to education, civic associations provide youth with the opportunity to improve their political knowledge and develop their political skills (Wong & Tseng, 2008).

### **Case Study: Floridian Cuban Americans**

With the variables of political socialization and data regarding the first- and second-generation immigrants in mind, taking a look at the political identities of Cuban Americans residing in Florida provides an applicable case study that outlines the nexus between age and socioeconomic experiences in political identity and engagement.

Upon the overthrowing of the Batista government and Fidel Castro’s ascent to power in 1959, the rate of emigration from Cuba to the United States dramatically increased to around 250,000 admissions from around 75,000 in the decade prior. In the next decade there was a

steady rate of emigrants from Cuba to the United States, to the tune of around 260,600. During the Mariel boatlift, around 124,800 emigrants left Cuba for America. With the fall of the Soviet Union, restrictive migration policies between Cuba and the United States were raised which lead to a sharp increase of 680,600 Cuban immigrants in America since 1980, meaning that there are a total of 1,279,000 Cuban immigrants in the United States now (Duany, 2021) (Batalova & Wei, 2023).

Even in the past 10 years there has been a 3% increase in the number of Cuban immigrants to the U.S, which was faster than the general immigrant population growth rate, further highlighting the fact that Cubans are “among the top 10 national-origin immigrant groups” (Batalova & Wei, 2023). Furthermore, the Cuban population in America is highly concentrated in Florida with 76% of Cuban immigrants residing in that state, and 52% living in Miami-Dade county (Batalova & Wei, 2023).

Immigration from Cuba is primarily grouped in regards to immigration prior to or after the 1980 Mariel boatlift, due to the demographic differences between the two eras of emigration from Cuba. In 1980, Cuban Prime Minister Fidel Castro and the Cuban government placed the Peruvian embassy in Havana under siege due to the thousands of Cubans attempting to seek asylum. Eventually, the Castro administration allowed those who sought to emigrate to do so between the months of April and September, with the majority of emigrants utilizing boats to travel to Florida. This became known as the 1980 Mariel Boatlift (Bishen & Klofstad, 2012). The variation of demographics between those who emigrated from Cuba before and after this event showcased a shift in motivations, which shifted from political to economic, and political identity. There is a political difference observed between those who emigrated prior to and after the Mariel boatlift in 1980.

### **Pre-Mariel Boatlift**

Those who have immigrated prior to the Mariel boatlift were primarily motivated by political reasons. This is due to their experiences of living under Castro's communist regime, which often involved having "property seized and relatives persecuted, imprisoned, or tortured", explaining their "fierce opposition to the Castro regime in Cuba" and sharing the Republican party's similar "anti-Castro, anti-communist" policy approach towards Cuba (Bishin & Klofstad, 2012, 588) (Girard et al., 2012, 43). Upon arriving in the United States, the Great Society programs provided the "highly skilled" pre-Mariel boatlift immigrants with economic opportunities, thereby supporting Cuban immigrants in establishing small businesses (Bishin & Klofstad, 2012, 588). This in turn led to this era of Cuban immigrants to align themselves with the Republican Party's economic and foreign policy stance, which was characterized by its "strong anti-communist stand" and "pro business and small government platforms" (Bishin & Klofstad, 2012, 588-9). The political partisanship of this demographic can be noted, as 73% identify themselves as Republican. Furthermore, the staunch opposition to Cuba's Communist regime can be seen with only 7.4% wanting to eliminate trade sanctions and 11.9% wanting to eliminate the travel ban (Bishin & Klofstad, 2012, 591).

### **Post-Mariel Boatlift**

In contrast, those who emigrated from Cuba to the United States after the Mariel boatlift of 1980 were doing so mainly for economic reasons and were primarily socialized during the Castro regime. This group of Cuban immigrants viewed immigration to the United States as an economic opportunity, with this group earning "about 50% less and [being] less likely to have a college degree" (Bishin & Klofstad, 2012, 589). Furthermore, this cohort was more likely to still retain close relations with family and friends who remained on the island. This perspective

influenced their political attitudes and preferences, as those who immigrated to America after the Mariel boatlift were more likely to want to eliminate trade sanctions and the travel ban, and less likely to be Republican (Bishin & Klofstad, 2012). It has been suggested that the desire to relieve the constructive nature of Cuban-American relations was due to the fact that many post-Mariel immigrants saw the “trade embargo and travel restrictions as hurting their family financially and impeding their ability to visit their relatives” (Bishin & Klofstad, 2012, 590). This connection between post-Mariel Cuban immigrants in America and Cuba results in “moderate political preferences” as they “lack the anti-Castro fervor” that had resulted in the pre-Mariel Cuban immigrants to embrace more conservative and Republican views (Bishin & Klofstad, 2012, 586).

### **Changing Politics?**

Over the course of the past twenty years, there have been fluctuations in regards to how Cuban Americans of Florida have politically identified. For a long time, Cuban Americans were noted for their tendency to support Republicans, which could be due to the aforementioned influences of the pre-Mariel boatlift Cuban immigrants. However, during the 2000s there was a slight decline in support from the Cuban American community in Florida for the Republican party. In 2002, 64% of registered Cuban voters identified with the Republican Party, while in 2013 less than half (47%) affiliated themselves with the GOP. In contrast, registered Cuban voters increasingly supported the Democratic Party with the support doubling from 22% to 44% within the same time period.

Concentrating now on Florida, where almost three quarters of the Cuban population live in America, the same trend could be noted. In the election of 2004, 78% of Cubans voted for President George W. Bush; however in 2012, only 47% voted for Mitt Romney, with more Cubans voting for President Barack Obama (Pew Research Center, 2020). Given that Florida has

long been regarded as a battleground state, this slight shift by the Cuban Americans in Florida had reemphasized this idea of being a “purple” state.

Differences between generations have been attributed to this trend of upward Democratic support. With the new immigrants and the children and succeeding generations of Cuban immigrants increasingly comprising a larger portion of the Cuban-American community as older immigrants are passing away, it is important to acknowledge the political identification of said group (Bishin & Klofstad, 2012). Among those between the ages of 18 and 49, 56% identified with the Democratic Party, compared to the 23% who aligned with the Republican Party. Those over the age of 50 are more likely to support the Republican Party with 44%, compared to the 23% who are Democrats. However, in 2002, 68% of registered voters of Cuban heritage identified themselves as Republicans, further suggesting that the Cuban-American community is becoming less Republican and more Democratic (Pew Research Center, 2020). This pattern has been observed in a study, based on the 2008 election exit poll in Miami-Dade, which found that “majority of Cuban Americans favored the Democratic presidential candidate in 2008, if they were U.S. born, emigrated in the 2000s, or were aged 18-29” (Girard et al., 2012, 54). These demographic groups “are more likely to be oriented toward the domestic concerns of Hispanic voters in the United States” which contrasts to the pre-Mariel Cuban immigrants who were influenced by their experiences which are “more closely tied to pre-Castro Cuba” (Girard et al., 2012, 54). Second generation Cuban immigrants and the subsequent generation are more likely to support eliminating trade sanctions and the travel ban than the first generation, with percentage point differences of 6.5 and 8.5 respectively. Furthermore, this cohort is less likely to be Republican (54.9%) compared to first generation immigrants (62.5%) with a percentage point difference of 7.6 (Bishin & Klofstad, 2012).

While there may have been a shift within the Cuban American community, it is important to note the socializing agents that may influence the degree to which these political preferences are implemented and therefore impact the political system. As mentioned in previous sections, the children of immigrants and their immigrant parents experience different socialization processes resulting in different attitudes, behaviors, preferences. For example, they “tend to hold increasingly progressive views..., less antipathy toward the Castro regime and decreased identification with the Republican party” (Bishin & Klofstad, 2012, 590).

However, these may be influenced by other factors such as family and friends, as well as institutions and education. While children of immigrants may develop their own perspective, the utilization of it may be shaped by pressures from family. With this in mind, “having been raised in staunchly Republican households, they tend to vote the party line” (Bishin & Klofstad, 2012, 590). The power of pressure from one’s social network has the capacity to modify one’s perspective towards a topic or event. Additionally, the ability for recent immigrants from Cuba to be able to have their political voice be heard is impacted by institutional contexts. The decline of welfare policies, which had provided socioeconomic support to pre-Mariel boatlift immigrants, in combination with the “lower socioeconomic background of post-Mariel immigrants” lead to a rise in the “costs of political participation by implicitly limiting who can receive the right to vote by becoming a citizen” (Bishin & Klofstad, 2012, 595).

Exit polls from the last two presidential elections showcase Florida to be swinging back to being more “red” and Republican, with former President Donald Trump winning the state with 48.6% in 2016 and with 51.2% in 2020 (Andre et al., 2020) (The New York Times, 2017). The margin by which Trump has won the state has increased, from +1.2 to +3.4, showcasing a growing base of support. Moreover, when comparing the 2016 and 2020 exit polls, Trump gained

support in Miami-Dade county, which as mentioned before, is predominately Cuban American (Collins et al., 2020). This could be attributed to the popularity of the Trump administration's hardline approach to Cuba. Over the course of his presidency, former President Trump reinstated an embargo with Cuba, with the administration "oppos[ing] calls in the United Nations and other international forums for its termination" (Trump White House, 2017). In 2019, the Trump administration announced further restrictions in regards to relations with Cuba, with Treasury Secretary Steven Mnuchin announcing that "this Administration has made a strategic decision to reverse the loosening of sanctions and other restrictions on the Cuban regime" (U.S. Department of the Treasury, 2019). As noted above, pre-Mariel boatlift Cuban immigrants are more likely to support this strict foreign policy approach, therefore it could be through parental and institutional influences that this political preference has been imparted unto second-generation Cuban immigrants, highlighting the capability of the status quo.

Much like it is important to differentiate between political preferences of the Democratic leaning Hispanic population and the Republican leaning Cuban-American community, it is critical to further examine this demographic for political variance based on identity, age, socioeconomic backgrounds, education, social networks, and origins (Krogstad, 2014). These variables have been shown to influence not only people's political attitudes and identification, but also whether they are able to be politically active and have their preferences recognized and reflected in laws and policies. Using the Cuban-American community as an example of the complexities of an immigrant group provides an opportunity to analyze the factors that shape the behaviors and attitudes of members. Furthermore, it showcases the stark differences between the first- and second-generation immigrants, highlighting the importance of acknowledging the variations within a specific group.

## Conclusion

How do people's environment affect their identity and, subsequently, their involvement in society and politics? Applying this question to the environments of second-generation immigrants illustrates how norms, expectations and pressures mold identities, which consequently yield certain political attitudes and behaviors. It has been shown that second-generation immigrants have the capacity to differ from their first-generation immigrant parents in this regard, thereby highlighting the importance of examining the subtleties in the variations and differences found within the broad experiences of immigrant families.

This thesis aimed to further the discussion surrounding the socialization and identity formation of the children of immigrants, who are also known as second-generation immigrants. How a person is socialized influences their identity, which are both reflected in an individual's political activity and preferences. Through an amalgamation of various sources, which included the legality of American citizenship, statistics and data surrounding immigration in the United States, various surveys and polls regarding the perception of American identity and immigration, comparisons between first- and second-generation immigrants in general and respective immigrant groups, sociological processes, and a case study, a better understanding of the experiences which second-generation immigrants can be reached. It showcases how these individuals are influenced by family, friends, school, civic organizations, and, thereby, the norms associated with these social networks. This can be noted as varying degrees of exposure to the language, politics and history of one's heritage shape one's identity. In turn, these attitudes and preferences have the capability to affect how, or even whether, a person politically participates in society.

The juxtaposing nature of American immigration should be acknowledged. On one end, the American Dream expresses a sense of egalitarian hope and idealism. This idea of America grounds itself in meritocracy, where through effort and dedication, those residing in America have the opportunity to achieve success. However, there are other variables at play which influence the actualization of the American Dream. The effects of an individual's socioeconomic status, the socialization dynamics of social networks, such as families and friends, and institutions like schools and civic associations must be recognized. The distinctive experiences that second-generation immigrants undergo must be addressed. These factors result in political preferences and attitudes that are different from those of their first-generation immigrant parents. The examination of the politics of second-generation immigrants is significant, as the differences highlighted in this thesis between first- and second-generation immigrants alone are considerable. Moreover, evaluating the generational differences among different immigrant groups and subsequently comparing results provides insight into the potential influence that one's heritage and experiences may have on one's political behaviors.

The experiences of second-generation immigrants are just one piece within the large and complex puzzle that is the American immigration system. As this allegory suggests, it is all interconnected, with the individual experience of first-generation immigrants influencing their relationship with politics, economics and society, and which in turn, influences succeeding generations. Also at play are variables, which range from personal identity to legal and socioeconomic status. The interaction between these variables shapes the experiences which first-generation immigrant parents, as well as their second-generation immigrant children have with the American government. The correlation between these individual experiences and

political participation is nuanced, therefore it is critical to examine it in order to better understand the implications of immigration policy on the experiences of immigrants.

With this demographic accounting for a substantial segment of the population, understanding what factors influence and shape it provides critical and useful insight into what motivates its political participation. This is especially true when attempting to better understand the political activities and preferences of such a large voting group that has undergone an individually unique political socialization process. Moreover, in light of major societal and political figures challenging the legality of second-generation immigrants' political participation, with their assertions questioning birthright citizenship. Subsequently, as such statements are made more prominent, with former President Trump stating at one point that he would remove birthright citizenship of those born to foreign nationals in the United States via an executive order, the basic ability to exercise one's basic rights and individuals of those born in the United States of America is being destabilized. Given the examples provided above, it is vital to protect the rights of the immigrant community and to explore ways to make integration processes – social, political, economic – less punitive and discriminatory and more reflective of the American Dream ideals.

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